

Claim Reopening and Internal Appeals Guide

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Audience: Claims adjusters and claims operations leadership

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This guide expands on the reopening reference in the Claims Handling Procedures Manual, Section 4.2, with the full reopening and internal appeal process.

1. Distinguishing Reopening from an Appeal

A claim is **reopened** when new factual information becomes available after a determination was made (a later-discovered repair estimate, a corrected policy version match, a quality-audit finding). A claim is subject to **internal appeal** when the policyholder disputes a determination made on the facts already in the file, without new information — these follow different processes described in Sections 2 and 3 respectively, and the adjuster's first task on any reopening or appeal request is classifying which one applies.

2. Reopening Process

A reopening request (whether policyholder-initiated, adjuster-initiated, or audit-initiated per the Claims Quality Assurance and Audit Program, Section 4) restarts the adjudication sequence from the step affected by the new information — a corrected policy-version match restarts from Step 1 of the Claims Adjudication Guidelines; a revised repair estimate restarts from Step 4 (the payout computation) without needing to re-run Steps 1 through 3 if the coverage and exclusion analysis are unaffected.

3. Internal Appeal Process

An internal appeal is reviewed by a claims supervisor who did not make the original determination, using only the facts already documented in the file plus any argument the policyholder raises about how those facts should be interpreted

against the Policy Wording. The reviewing supervisor confirms whether the original five-step sequence was correctly applied and correctly cited — this is the same standard used in the internal quality audit — and either upholds or overturns the original determination, documenting the reasoning either way.

4. Appeal Timeframe

A policyholder may request an internal appeal within the timeframe stated in the claim determination letter; a request received after that window is still reviewed if the delay is reasonably explained, but is otherwise handled as a new complaint under the Complaint Handling Procedure rather than as a standard-track appeal.

5. Overturned Determinations

Where an appeal or reopening results in a different outcome than the original determination, the claim file is updated with an addendum documenting the change and its basis (Claims Handling Procedures Manual, Section 4.2) — the original determination and its citations are preserved in the file, not deleted, so the record shows the full history of how the claim was handled.

6. Relationship to Litigation

Where a policyholder has already engaged legal counsel or filed suit over a determination, the internal appeal process in Section 3 is not a prerequisite to litigation and does not pause any litigation timeline — a policyholder may pursue both simultaneously, and Meridian Mutual continues to process a pending internal appeal on its own timeline regardless of a parallel legal filing, per the Litigation and Legal Referral Guide.

7. Repeated Appeals on the Same Determination

An appeal that raises no new argument beyond one already reviewed and upheld under Section 3 is not re-reviewed from scratch — it is answered by referencing the prior appeal review's reasoning, unless the policyholder identifies a specific factual or interpretive point the prior review did not address.

8. Appeals Involving a Deterministic Computation

Where an appeal disputes the arithmetic of a payout rather than the coverage determination itself, the reviewing supervisor re-runs the deterministic calculation service with the same inputs to confirm the original figure, rather than manually recomputing it — this preserves the corpus-wide rule that no payout figure is ever produced or verified by narrative judgment alone.